7.3 Populists and Social Media: IOs Fight Back

Social media has become a battleground where populists skillfully mobilize public opinion against their opposition, including IOs. Leaders often leverage platforms like Twitter to portray IOs as scapegoats for unpopular policies or as symbols of overreaching global elitism, which helps them consolidate domestic support (Vreeland 1999; Handlin, Kaya, and Günaydin 2023). For instance, European populist actors frequently broadcast anti-EU messages, emphasizing fears about sovereignty loss (Alonso-Muñoz and Casero-Ripollés 2020). Similarly, US president Donald Trump used Twitter to rail against "globalists," criticizing multilateral institutions like the WTO and the UN.[9]

However, little extant research has explored whether IOs counter populist messaging, or if their efforts can effectively sway public opinion (though see Dellmuth and Tallberg [2023]). We examine whether IOs can adopt populist-style communication on social media to influence public sentiment. Populist leaders have demonstrated how anti-elite, people-centered messaging resonates with the public (Bakker, Schumacher, and Rooduijn 2021). We argue that IOs may be able to co-opt this strategy to win back trust and legitimacy.

Reversing public opposition is no easy feat for IOs. Citizens often hold deeply entrenched partisan beliefs, using these affiliations to form opinions on complex issues like international cooperation (Schlipphak, Meiners, and Kiratli 2022). Such partisan attachments make people more likely to accept information that aligns with their preconceptions and reject opposing views (Zaller 1992; Brewer 2001). These dynamics may pose a barrier to IOs' efforts to reshape public attitudes.

Furthermore, adopting populist-style rhetoric could clash with IOs' technocratic and elite identities. Bureaucrats within these institutions may hesitate to use simplified or emotionally charged messaging, fearing that it could undermine their credibility, which is crucial for advancing institutional mandates and sustaining career success. Indeed, some officials may prefer to ignore populist threats and maintain the status quo operationally, hoping such threats are blips that fade over time.[10] Additionally, IOs may be perceived as biased or self-interested actors when touting their people-centrism online (Dellmuth and Tallberg 2023).